



PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR

against the strong home-grown milk cooperatives. One of the key factors, say experts, in Parle Agro's early success in the category this time is its pricing. While dairy beverages packed in carton or PET bottles from most leading brands are priced at a premium than packaged colas, Chauhan has priced her dairy beverages—sold under the SMOODH brand—at a

WHY SHE MATTERS

As the leader of one of the country's largest home-grown beverages maker, Chauhan has not only managed to grow her business under challenging circumstances but has also stood strong against the two American cola giants



SCHAUNA CHAUHAN

48, CEO, Parle Agro

lower price band, starting at ₹10. "At least for the next two years, there's going to be tremendous amount of focus on our dairy based beverages. We've recently launched *lassi* and launched flavoured milk a year ago. So, there's going to be tremendous amount of focus on distribution for our milk-based products as well," she says.

Additionally, to back her aggressive plans, Chauhan is also working to increase production capacity as the new products attract consumers' attention. The company is already in the process of investing in two greenfield projects in Vijayawada and Gwalior to ramp up production.

For Chauhan, who is actively working to diversify Parle Agro's portfolio that is now heavily skewed towards its traditional brand Frooti (it contributes 45-50% towards its top line) believes in the 'learning on the go' mantra.

"The best form of education is practical education," says Chauhan, who now has close to two and half decades of experience under her belt. "Because you know, during difficult decision-making, data may drive you towards one direction, while your intuition may point towards a completely opposite way. That is when your experience comes in handy," Chauhan tells *BT*.

It is no wonder then that after taking the plunge during the difficult times and, eventually, setting her house in order, Parle Agro has managed to grow 12% year-on-year during the summer months this year. **BT**

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